

This Is How The World Actually Works



POWER & WILL - MACHIAVELLI BOT

AUG 14, 2026

At some point you learned to read, do math, maybe even negotiate a lease. Nobody ever sat you down and taught you how power actually moves through a room, why some people get walked over their entire lives while others never seem to lose an argument, or why the person who seems the most confident at the party is so often the most fragile one in it. You were left to figure that out through trial, error, and a fair amount of getting burned.

This is my attempt to write down what I've noticed, tested, and had confirmed the hard way. None of it is about becoming ruthless. It's about refusing to walk through your own life half blind, seeing only the version of people and situations you'd prefer to see instead of what's actually there.

Thanks for reading! Subscribe for free to receive new posts and support my work.

[Pledge your support](#)

Rules Are a Crutch

You've been given a hundred pieces of advice that sound like laws. "Always negotiate from strength. Never let them see you sweat. Give people the benefit of the doubt." Every one of these is true sometimes and false just as often, and the moment you apply any of them

automatically, without asking whether this specific situation actually calls for it, you've stopped thinking and started performing a ritual.

The people who actually navigate life well aren't the ones with the best rulebook. They're the ones who can look at a situation fresh and ask what it actually requires, even when that answer contradicts what worked perfectly last time. Circumstances shift underneath you constantly: the job market changes, the relationship changes, the person across the table changes. A rule that doesn't bend with it isn't wisdom. It's just superstition that happens to sound smart.

So before you reach for a tactic, even one of the ones in this piece, ask yourself what's actually different about your situation right now. Memorizing tactics without developing judgment is more dangerous than having no tactics at all, because it gives you false confidence exactly when you need real observation.

Everyone Is Performing, Including You

Most people you deal with are not lying to you outright. They're doing something subtler: presenting a curated, flattering version of themselves and hoping you mistake it for the whole picture. The confident colleague, the endlessly supportive friend, the boss who never seems to lose his temper. None of that is necessarily fake. It's just incomplete, and the gap between the performance and the reality only shows up under pressure.

That's where you should actually be looking. Not at how someone behaves when everything is going well and they have an audience, but at what they do the moment something small goes wrong. How they talk about the people who used to be close to them and no longer are. What happens the one time you push back on them in front of other people. Those moments are where the performance slips and you get a look at the operating system underneath.

Here's the part people skip: you're doing the exact same thing. You have a version of yourself you present, and a version that shows up when you're tired, cornered, or embarrassed. If you've spent all your energy learning to read other people and none learning to catch yourself in the act, you've only done half the work, and it's the easier half.

You Are Not as Peaceful as You Think

Somewhere along the way you probably absorbed the idea that aggression is something other people have and you don't, that anger and ambition are character flaws you've mostly outgrown. This is a comfortable story and it's almost never true. That drive, the urge to push forward, claim territory, and insist on what you're worth, isn't a defect. It's the same energy that gets anything built at all. Suppress it completely and it doesn't disappear, it just leaks out sideways, as sarcasm, as quiet sabotage, as the kind of "I'm fine" that clearly means the opposite.

The people who do the most damage with their aggression are rarely the ones who admit they have any. They're the ones who've convinced themselves they're above it, right up until it comes out in a form nobody, including them, saw coming. The useful move isn't pretending you don't have this in you. It's getting familiar enough with it that you can see it coming and choose, deliberately, where it goes.

Integrate your emotions. Read my article on [Shadow Integration for the exact process of how to do it.](#)

Nobody Was Ever Persuaded by What You Wanted

Think about the last time someone tried to convince you of something by explaining, at length, why it mattered to them. It probably didn't

move you much. Now think about the last time someone understood exactly what you cared about and framed their ask around that. That one probably worked, even if you couldn't have explained why at the time.

This is the entire secret of influence and almost nobody applies it, because it requires setting aside what you want long enough to actually think about what the other person wants. Not what you assume they want. What they actually, specifically want, which usually takes real attention to figure out. Once you know that, you stop wrestling to persuade and start to actually convince: taking your ask and expressing it in terms that already matter to them.

Watch for the cheaper version of this too, because it's used on you constantly. Repetition of a loaded word until it stops sounding like an opinion and starts sounding like a fact. Bold, confident language that moves too fast for you to ask whether it's actually true. Advertisers do it, political campaigns do it, and so does the coworker who always seems to get their way. Once you notice the mechanism, it mostly stops working on you, which is the whole point of learning it.

Trust Is a Strategy, Not a Virtue

Here's where most advice about power goes wrong. It tells you to stay guarded, assume the worst, never let anyone get close enough to use it against you. This is not being sophisticated, more likely, it is being driven by fear.

There's a genuinely elegant answer to the question of how much to trust people, and it isn't "never" or "always." It's simple, and it's been tested more rigorously than almost anything else in this territory. Start by cooperating in good faith. Then simply mirror what the other person does. If they act in good faith, you keep doing the same. The moment they don't, you respond in kind, immediately and without ambiguity. And

the instant they come back in good faith, you go right back to cooperating, no grudge, no lingering punishment.

This beats permanent suspicion because permanent suspicion poisons every relationship before it has a chance to prove itself, and it beats naive, unconditional trust because that gets exploited by the small number of people who are actually looking to take advantage. The strategy that wins, over and over, is the one that's generous by default, clear about its boundaries, and completely unsentimental about enforcing them.

Authority Isn't Given, It Accumulates

You can't argue your way into being trusted. You can't insist your way into being respected. Both of those get earned the slow way, through a pattern of staying steady when things go sideways, being straight with people even when a comfortable lie would be easier, and following through on the boring stuff nobody's watching. Authority is a residue. It builds up quietly in the minds of the people who've seen you handle difficulty well, and it evaporates fast the moment you stop deserving it.

If you find yourself constantly explaining, justifying, and pushing your point of view uphill against resistance, that's usually not a sign you need a better argument. It's a sign the trust hasn't been built yet, and no amount of talking faster is going to substitute for it.

The Part You'll Want to Skip

It's much easier to read all of this as a manual for understanding everyone else: their tells, their masks, their patterns. It is far more useful, and far less comfortable, to turn it on yourself.

You almost certainly believe that when you've acted badly it was because you were pushed into a corner, while when other people act badly it's simply who they are. Nearly everyone believes this about

themselves. It's one of the most reliable and least examined habits of mind there is, and it's expensive, because it means the pattern everyone around you can already see in you is the one thing you never bother to check.

The people who actually get good at reading power and human nature are the ones willing to admit they're built from the same material as everyone they're trying to understand. That's an uncomfortable admission. It's also where whatever real advantage exists in any of this actually comes from. You cannot see clearly in others what you refuse to look at in yourself.

Where This Leaves You

None of this is a set of tricks to memorize. It's a posture: look closely instead of assuming, judge each situation by what it actually needs instead of by habit, default to believing people are acting out of self-interest and competence rather than pure malice or pure altruism, extend trust deliberately and defend it the moment it's tested, and hold yourself to the same unflattering scrutiny you'd love to reserve for everyone else.

People will call this cynical. It isn't. Cynicism is deciding in advance that people are bad and giving up on looking any closer. What I'm describing is the opposite: the discipline of paying attention, continuously, without deciding ahead of time what you'll find. It's uncomfortable work. It's also the only thing I've found that actually stops you from being blindsided, by the people around you, or by yourself.

P.S. This post is only a small part of what has been preserved inside Fifty Shades of Sanity: The Forbidden Archive.

The archive is my private collection. It contains the deleted threads,

long-form essays, and private lessons on power, status, discipline, strategy, and human behavior that were too detailed to fit into a single post.

[You can access the full archive here](#)

Thanks for reading! Subscribe for free to receive new posts and support my work.

Pledge your support